



**COLORADO STATE
UNIVERSITY**

Final Project Workshop – Digital Story & 3MT

Turning Your Mentor's Decision into a 3-Minute Story

Today's Goals

By the end of today, you will:

- Translate your written **Decision Memo** into a clear, engaging story.
- Use **storytelling techniques** to hook and guide your audience.
- Apply a **3MT-style structure** to your 2–3 minute digital story.
- Leave with a **storyboard** and draft outline for your presentation.



Where We're At

You have:

1. A mentor
2. A **decision point** and **options**
3. A draft memo outline (Background, Decision, Considerations, Ask)

Today = “**How do we tell this as a story?**”

Goal: Make it **simple, clear, and compelling** in 3–5 minutes.

Storytelling in Presentations

What makes a presentation memorable?

Common elements:

1. A **strong opening** (hook)
2. A clear **through-line** (one main message)
3. **Concrete examples** instead of vague generalities
4. Clear **stakes** (“Why does this matter?”)
5. A purposeful **ending** (the Ask)

Storytelling Example – Hooking the Audience

We'll watch a short video on public speaking and audience engagement:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=k8GvTgWtR7o>

While you watch, write down:

2–3 techniques the speaker uses to **hook** the audience

1 thing they do to keep ideas **simple and clear**

Debrief

Turn to someone near you and discuss (2–3 minutes):

- What was **one specific hook** you noticed?
- How did the speaker make complex ideas feel **simple**?

Then share a few examples with the class.

What is 3MT?

3 Minute Thesis (3MT):

- A format where you explain a complex idea in **3 minutes**, no jargon.
- Focus on:
 - One **main idea**
 - Simple, accessible **language**
 - A clear **beginning–middle–end**
- We'll look at an example and adapt its structure to your mentor stories.

3MT Example – Clear, Concise, Compelling

Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PczCM3GwB4Q>

As you watch, note:

- How does the speaker **start**?
- How does the speaker **organize** the talk?
- What makes the message **stick**?

3MT Rules You Can Steal

For your Digital Story:

- **One clear message**
 - “This is a story about a founder who must decide whether to ___ or ___.”
- **Simple structure**
 - Beginning: who they are + why the business exists
 - Middle: the decision + options + stakes
 - End: the Ask (your discussion question)
- **No jargon:** explain like you would to a smart friend in a different major.
- **Time:** aim for **3–5 minutes** of spoken content.

6-Frame Structure for Your Story

We'll use a simple 6-frame storyboard:

1. **Hook** – a vivid moment, quote, or tension
2. **Background** – mentor + business in 2–3 key points
3. **Build Context** – how we got to the decision
4. **Decision & Options** – what's at stake, what are the choices
5. **Stakes & Considerations** – why it's hard, what they must weigh
6. **The Ask** – your discussion question for the audience

You'll fill this out on your *Storyboard Handout* (worksheet).

Activity: Storyboard Your Digital Story

Instructions (15–20 minutes):

- Sit with your group.
- Use the **Storyboard Handout** (worksheet).
- For each of the 6 frames, sketch:
 - What you might **say** (include specific phrases)
 - What you might **show** (images, simple visuals)
- Goal: Leave with a **working plan**, not a perfect script.

Activity: 90-Second Practice Pitch

Partner up with another group.

Round 1:

- Group A gives a **90-second** verbal version of their story (no slides).
- Group B answers:
 - What was the **main message**?
 - What part felt most **engaging**?
 - Where did you get **confused**?

Round 2:

- Switch roles and repeat.

Next Steps & Checklist

Before your final submission, your team should have:

1. A **finished Decision Memo** (2–3 pages, clear decision + options + considerations + Ask).
2. A **digital story** (3–5 minutes) that:
 - Follows a clear beginning–middle–end
 - Makes the decision and stakes easy to follow
 - Ends with your **Ask**

Use your storyboard and today's feedback to build your script and visuals.

Summary

- ✓ Translate your written Decision Memo into a clear, engaging story.
- ✓ Use storytelling techniques to hook and guide your audience.
- ✓ Apply a 3MT-style structure to your 2–3 minute digital story.
- ✓ Leave with a storyboard and draft outline for your presentation.

